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Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines); (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and
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Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 • Hamilton
House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 2332233; Fax: 23327330 • 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai,
2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phones: 2847526-41; Telex: 041-6177 Into In; Fax: 28472178; Cable:
Livmedia Chennai • 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones:
22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore • 52, Jawaharlal Nehru Road,
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• 2/C, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006;
Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293

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The nature of their profession makes most journalists cynical. I would say I am especially so when it comes to politicians. I have seen there are no gods in politics. Sooner or later, we discover their feet of clay. I must confess I dropped my cynicism when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh announced the path-breaking nuclear agreement with US President George Bush on July 18, 2005.

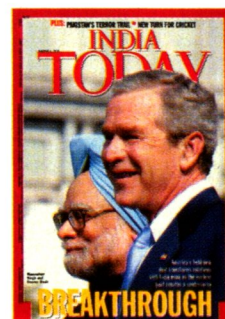
If the agreement had been consummated, it would have meant an end to India's nuclear isolation and pariah status amongst nuclear weapon states. It would have given India a place in the high table of nations. It would have cemented our relationship with the world's superpower and given the alternative energy sector the boost it badly needed. We put it on the cover with the headline: "Breakthrough". It seemed our self-effacing prime minister had finally found the signature deed he would want to be remembered by. With this, the prime minister was coming into his own and no more behaving like a puppet-on-a-string.

The two followed this up during Bush's maiden visit in March 2006 by agreeing on a separation plan critical to the deal. On that occasion, the prime minister waxed eloquent, "History has been made. America is now a partner, friend and a well-wisher." My conviction about him grew when he dared the Left, as recently as in August this year, to withdraw support if they didn't approve of the deal.

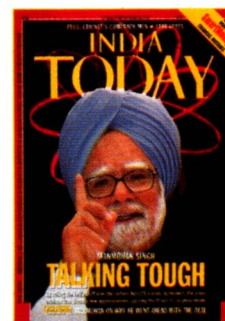
Last week, I regretted having dropped my usual cynicism when Manmohan did a complete somersault and declared: "If the deal does not come through, it is not the end of life." He has obviously lost his nerve, his spine, his conviction and now his place in history. He has joined the swelling ranks of opportunistic politicians who infest our polity. Manmohan knew that the Left was opposed to the nuclear deal from the beginning but he still went ahead. In fact, much to its credit, the Left is the only political group which has held on to its convictions in spite of the prospect of a general election.

Our cover story analyses the reasons behind Manmohan's meltdown and the UPA's retreat on the nuclear deal. Our diplomatic and political bureau also examines the consequences of the stalled deal and its future. More important than the loss of credibility of a prime minister, is the fact that India has lost. Not only are we shame-faced in the international arena but most probably missed a deal which is good for India. Worse, Manmohan Singh is now a lame-duck prime minister. And I have learnt my lesson.

(Aroon Purie)



Our August 2005 cover



Our August 2007 cover